

SDG 12

SDG 15



SDA CHALLENGE 2026 · University of Potsdam

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Your mission: The University of Potsdam wants to make its campuses greener, more biodiverse, and more inviting – without a million-euro budget. You are working as a real consulting team for the Green Office. Your ideas should be **actionable, affordable, and sustainable long-term**. Think: what could actually be implemented by a public university with limited resources?

All five groups work on the same overarching challenge, but each team chooses **one concrete site** and scenario below. This lets you compare approaches and learn from each other during the final pitch session.

1. STEP: Choose one of the challenges

Option A

Wildflower Meadow *Campus Neues Palais*

A lawn area on Campus Neues Palais is currently underused and ecologically barren. Design a wildflower meadow concept – including native plant selection, a long-term maintenance plan, and a strategy for engaging the campus community in caring for it.



Option B

Tiny Forest *Campus Golm*

A compact but dense urban forest by e.g. using the Miyawaki method – many native trees, shrubs, and ground cover planted close together on a small footprint. Design the concept, species selection, soil preparation, and a realistic implementation and stewardship plan.



Option C

Gravel into Green *Campus Neues Palais*

A sealed gravel surface contributes to heat and water runoff. Transform it into a sustainable space that promotes biodiversity and social life – a place students and staff actually want to spend time in. Consider seating, planting, and soil unsealing.



2. STEP: Prepare a proposal

Your deliverables

This approach includes the key benefits that your concept is expected to create.

DELIVERABLE 1 Concept overview A clear description of your proposed intervention: what it is, why this site needs it and why you have chosen it.	DELIVERABLE 2 Sustainability rationale How does your concept contribute to SDG 12 (responsible consumption & materials) and SDG 15 (life on land)?
DELIVERABLE 3 Visual concept A sketch, diagram, or simple visual – layout, planting zones, or social use areas. Hand-drawn is perfectly fine.	DELIVERABLE 4 Implementation & maintenance plan Who does what, and when? A rough timeline and a clear answer to: how does this space survive after the initial project?
DELIVERABLE 5 Community engagement idea One idea for how students or staff can actively participate – in building, maintaining, or learning from the space.	OPTIONAL Awareness element A small communication idea that makes your intervention legible to passersby – a sign, a campaign, a QR code, or an event.

3. STEP: Present your vision

Your final pitch

Every team presents their concept as a short, compelling pitch to the group and the commissioner. **You will receive pitch training beforehand.** Think of it as presenting to a real decision-maker: be concrete, be confident, make it easy to say yes.



Total pitch time: approx. 8-10 minutes per group. Visual aids welcome, a sketch or a few slides are enough. Content and clarity matter most. The outline above is only intended as a guide. Teams are free to choose their own structure and timing.

We can't wait to see your ideas. Have fun!

1.Appendix: Before you start - keep this in mind

Low budget Think like a public institution. Creative, cost-effective solutions over architectural fantasy. Upcycled materials, student labor, and local partnerships count.	Feasible & maintainable Who takes care of your space after year one? Factor in maintenance, ownership, and institutional responsibilities from the start.	People-centered Students, researchers, and staff all use these spaces. Your design should create real value for the campus community — not just look good on paper.
Budget <u>Wildflower Meadow</u> 15.000€	<u>Tiny Forest</u> 15.000€	<u>Gravel into Green</u> 5.000€

2.Appendix: How to approach the challenge

Your working process

1. Explore & understand the site
- Research your chosen location. What's there now? What are its ecological and social weaknesses? Use the background materials (Biodiversity Concept, Sustainability Report) and think about physical conditions: soil, sunlight, drainage, foot traffic.
2. Define your intervention
- What exactly will you change or create? Be specific: which plants, which materials, which structures? Ground your choices in the university's biodiversity goals (native species, drought resilience, ecological corridors).
3. Plan for sustainability — beyond the first season
- How does your intervention sustain itself over time? Who maintains it? How do you involve students, staff, or existing initiatives. Think about community ownership and long-term impact.
4. Make sustainability visible
- Your space should communicate why it exists. Think about a small awareness element — a sign, a QR code, or a participatory format that invites people to engage with the space and its purpose.

5. Do a quick feasibility check
- Roughly: Who is responsible for implementation? What are the biggest hurdles (permissions, money, timing)? What would a first small step look like — a pilot that could happen within the next semester?

3.Appendix: Use these to guide your thinking

Guiding questions

? How can we create meaningful ecological impact with a very small budget and limited space?	? Which native plants are best suited to the Brandenburg climate, especially with hotter, drier summers?
? How do we ensure the space keeps functioning after the project team is gone?	? What makes a green space genuinely useful and attractive to the people who study and work on campus?

? How can existing student initiatives (e.g. StuGa, NAJU UP) be involved as partners rather than just beneficiaries?	? What low-cost materials or methods (upcycling, community sourcing, DIY) could be used in your design?
? How can your concept serve as a visible example that inspires others to act sustainably on campus?	? What would a realistic first pilot step look like – something that could happen in the next 3–6 months?

4.Appendix: SDA Alignment

Link to global goals

Your work directly contributes to two UN Sustainable Development Goals. Reflect on these connections in your concept – they strengthen your pitch and ground your ideas in a broader context.

SDG 12 <i>Responsible Consumption & Production</i> Use upcycled, regional, or resource-efficient materials. Minimize waste. Favour circular approaches.	SDG 15 <i>Life on Land</i> Support native flora & fauna, improve the microclimate, unseal surfaces, create ecological corridors on campus.
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5.Appendix: Helpful additional information

Background resources

The following resources provide important context for your challenge. Read the summaries included in your challenge pack, and use these links to explore the full documents if you want to go deeper. Your mentor Tara Meghana Kaila can help you navigate the most relevant sections.

Official University Documents

Sustainability Report Overview of the university's sustainability strategy, CO₂ targets, campus & biodiversity measures, and governance. A good starting point for understanding the UP's goals and achievements. → <u>Open Sustainability Report page</u>	Biodiversity Concept (2024) The official biodiversity strategy adopted by the university senate in June 2024. Covers site-specific goals, species protection, vegetation management and ecological corridors. Directly relevant for all three scenarios. (only in german) → <u>Open Biodiversity Concept (PDF)</u>
Climate Protection Concept The university's integrated climate protection plan (2020). Covers energy, mobility, campus infrastructure and CO₂ reduction pathways. Useful for understanding why soil sealing and green spaces matter for the overall climate strategy. → <u>Summary (PDF)</u> <u>Full concept page</u>	Environmental Portal (Umweltportal) The central hub for all sustainability information at UP – reports, working groups, measures, and current projects. Run by the Green Office and the Commission for Environment and Mobility (UMK). → <u>Open Environmental Portal</u>

Student initiatives at the University of Potsdam

These initiatives are active on campus and could be valuable partners for your project, both as sources of knowledge and as potential collaborators for implementation and maintenance. **Many of their websites might be in German, but don't hesitate to reach out in English.** It's widely spoken at the university.

SINC - runs hands-on sustainability projects across campus, from planting fruit trees to energy-saving campaigns and bringing people together to share ideas

NAJU - brings students together for nature, climate and environmental protection, from building nest boxes and insect hotels to litter clean-ups, discussion rounds and campus parties

Bunte Wiese Potsdam ("colorful meadows") - creates more diverse meadows across campus and the city, mown just twice a year so plants can flower and boost biodiversity - paired with monitoring, public outreach and environmental education.

Stud oec - promotes sustainability in teaching and campus life, organizing interdisciplinary lectures and project seminars on social, ecological and economic sustainability each term, alongside projects like the Kippenkontest against cigarette litter.

StuGa - is a 280 m² community garden on Campus Golm, run by biology students since 2012, where vegetables and herbs are grown using ecological methods.

Lesecafé Golm - is a student free space on Campus Golm, open for whatever you feel like, from a morning coffee or as an alternative to the library, always open and ready to visit, where you can meet, work on the challenges and spend time together.

6. Appendix: Things to keep in mind on site

Wildflower Meadow - This location is home to several invasive species, including *Ailanthus altissima* (tree of heaven), which we would like to see removed. It aggressively outcompetes and displaces other plants and trees.

Tiny Forest - There is a large electrical/utility box here that should remain in place and must stay accessible, but it should be screened from vandalism with green planting. The hedges currently there are non-native, possibly even sterile (no nectar, etc.), so they offer nothing to native insects. The idea is therefore to replace them and design the area a bit larger.

Gravel into Green - This corner of Campus Neues Palais has quietly declined over time. What was once a modest seating area has been reduced to a sealed gravel surface, a bin, and an uninviting dead end — neither green nor social, neither functional nor welcoming. The fully sealed ground prevents rainwater from infiltrating the soil, contributes to surface heat, and offers nothing to local biodiversity. Meanwhile, the campus faces a persistent shortage of informal gathering spots — places where students and staff can sit down between lectures, meet spontaneously, or simply spend time outside. We'd love to see this space transformed into something that actually serves the people and nature around it. Greener, more social, more alive — but how exactly? That's for you to decide.

7. Appendix: Challenges & Institutional Landscape

What are you working within

The following points summarise the institutional context at the University of Potsdam — prepared by Mareike Friedrich (Green Office). Understanding these dynamics will help you design proposals that are genuinely implementable.

Diversity of approaches across faculties

Natural and life sciences, social sciences, and teacher training all approach sustainability differently. Measures that are easy to quantify in the sciences may be harder to evaluate in the humanities. Your proposal needs to speak across these differences.

Fragmented student engagement

Many sustainability initiatives exist, but there is limited coordination, visibility, and shared knowledge between them. Groups like FlyingLess and BNE@UP have been recently revived. Your concept could build on or connect to existing efforts rather than starting from scratch.

Institutional and budgetary constraints

The university has different decision-making processes across faculties, and some campuses (especially Neues Palais) are subject to heritage protection rules. Resources for physical interventions are limited. Low-cost, step-by-step approaches that can start small and grow are more likely to succeed.

Communication and acceptance

Different levels of knowledge and attitudes towards sustainability across campus require targeted communication. What works for biology students may not resonate in law or economics. Think about how to make your concept visible and relatable across disciplines.